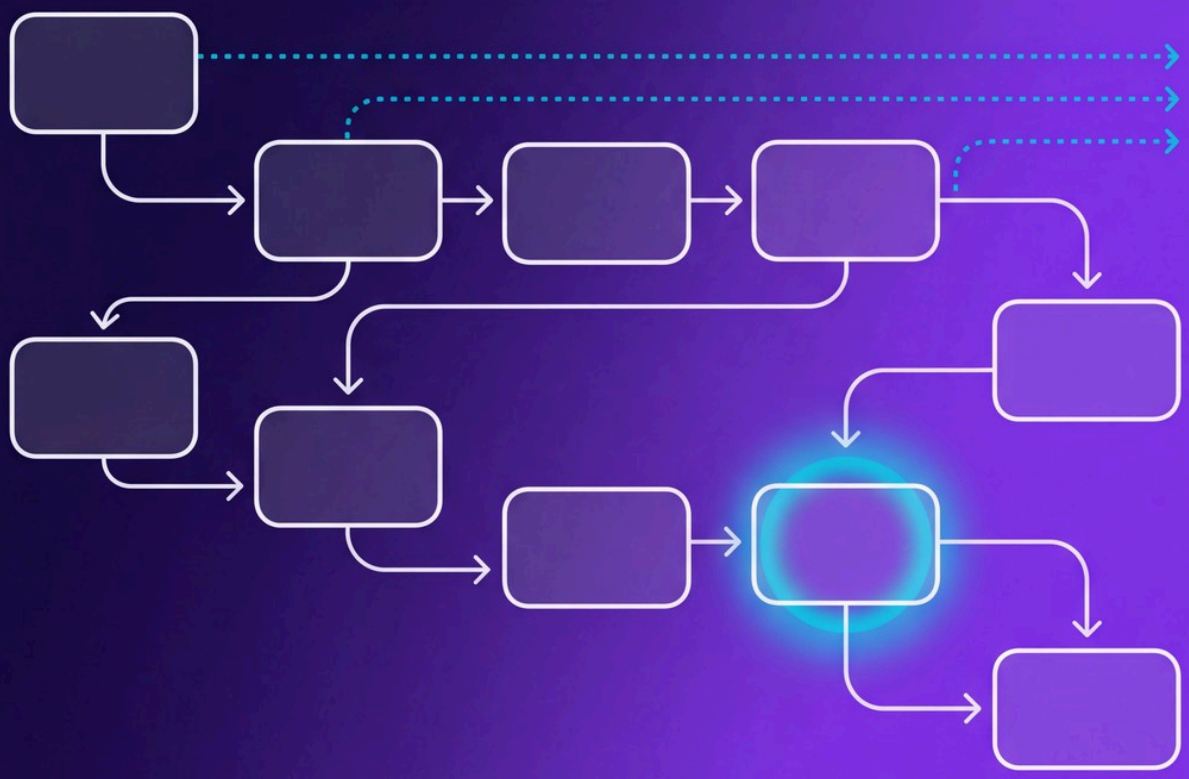
FREE PLAYBOOK

# The Client Recovery SOP For Agencies

10 stages. 100 scripts. Save the account.



AI BrandFactory

**10 conversation stages. 100 scripted lines. 6 ready-to-send templates. The severity matrix. The 2026 channel rules. The chapter on when to fire the client instead.**

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## Who this is for

Solo freelancers, agency owners, and in-house growth operators dealing with client conflict in 2026. If you have ever stared at a Slack message for an hour trying to figure out what to write back, this is the SOP you keep open while you draft the reply.

I have lost three accounts to silence. One to a Slack message that should have been a phone call. One to a panic Loom I sent before I had a plan inside it. A fourth to a discount I offered before I had even let the client finish their sentence.

Every loss traces to the same thing: no system. I was reacting from gut, and my gut was scared. This is the system I built afterwards. Eight parts. Hit the one you need on the day you need it.

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## What is in this SOP


- **Part 1**, The Damage Assessment
- **Part 2**, The 10 Stages of Recovery
- **Part 3**, 2026 Channel Decisions
- **Part 4**, The Severity Routing Matrix
- **Part 5**, The Template Library
- **Part 6**, The Recovery Tracking Scorecard
- **Part 7**, The 12 Mistakes To Never Make
- **Part 8**, When to Fire the Client Instead

# Part 1, The Damage Assessment

Every recovery starts here. Read the room before you write a word back. Get this read wrong and the rest of the SOP cannot save you.

## The 3 client moods you are diagnosing

**Confused.** Not angry. They do not understand what happened or what it means for them. Confusion turns to frustration if you ignore it for two days. Fix: information, fast and clear.

**Frustrated.** They understand. They are unhappy. They are not yet talking about ending the relationship. Frustration turns into a quiet decision to shop around. Fix: acknowledgment, ownership, visible plan.

**Ready to fire.** No more questions, just statements. "We need to talk." "This is not working." "Can you send over our assets." Read this as frustrated and you lose the account inside 72 hours.

The single biggest first-hour mistake is misreading mood three as mood two. When in doubt, treat it as the more serious mood. You can de-escalate downwards. You almost never get to escalate upwards in time.

## The 3 severity tiers

## The Severity Routing Matrix

**Three tiers.** Channel, re**sponse window**, follow-up, cadence. Stop guessing under pressure.

| TIER | WHAT IT IS | CHANNEL | RESPONSE WINDOW | WRITTEN FOLLOW-UP | CHECK-IN CADENCE |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Tier 1 | Minor frustration. Late report, typo, missed Slack. Relationship fine. | Slack or email | Within 4 hours | None beyond initial reply | One follow-up at 7 days |
| Tier 2 | Actively pissed. Blown deadline, deliverable miss, surprise bill. | Phone or Loom plus written | Within 24 hours | Plan with owners and dates within 48 hours | Weekly written for 30 days |
| Tier 3 | Account at risk. Real consequence to client business. | Video or in-person plus written | Within 24 hours | Full Recovery Plan within 5 business days | Weekly for 30 days, then biweekly to 90 |

**Tier 1, minor frustration.** A late report. A typo in a deck. A missed Slack message. The client is annoyed but the relationship is fine. Recoverable in one or two messages.

**Tier 2, actively pissed.** A blown deadline that affected their week. A deliverable that fell short of the brief. A bill they were not expecting. The client is using language like "I am frustrated" or "this needs to change". The relationship survives if you handle the next three days well.

**Tier 3, account at risk.** The client has used the words "fire", "end", "leave", "switch", "concerned about whether to continue". Or there has been a real-world consequence to their business (a launch missed, a revenue hit, a partnership embarrassed). The relationship survives only with a real recovery plan, in writing, and weekly check-ins for the next 30 days.

Most agencies under-classify. They look at a Tier 3 message and tell themselves it is a Tier 2 because Tier 3 means doing more work. Read the message twice and assume the worse tier.

### The 24-hour acknowledgment rule

Every escalation gets an acknowledgment within 24 hours. No exceptions. Not a solution, not a plan. Just a message that lands in their inbox or Slack inside 24 hours.

At hour 25, the client decides you do not care. They start planning their exit while waiting for your reply. Even a brilliant message later lands on a client who has already moved on emotionally.

Three sentences is enough: "I have read your message. I want to give it the response it deserves, and I am working on it now. You will hear from me with specifics by [exact day and time within 48 hours]."

### The first message you send (regardless of tier)

Four things, in this order:

1. Acknowledge you received it
2. Acknowledge how they are feeling, in their own words if possible
3. Tell them when you will follow up with specifics
4. Stop. Do not try to solve anything in the first message.

The fourth is the one operators get wrong. Solving in the first reply feels like progress. It is not. Solving without listening makes the client feel unheard, which is the same emotional injury that started the conflict. Hold the solution for message two.

> The full library has more templates like this. Adjacent SOPs at aibrandfactory.com.

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## Part 2, The 10 Stages of Recovery

Most recovery conversations move through these 10 stages in order. Some you skim, some you cannot skip. Jump to stage 7 (Actionable Steps) before stage 1 (Empathetic Acknowledgment) and the client reads your plan as deflection.

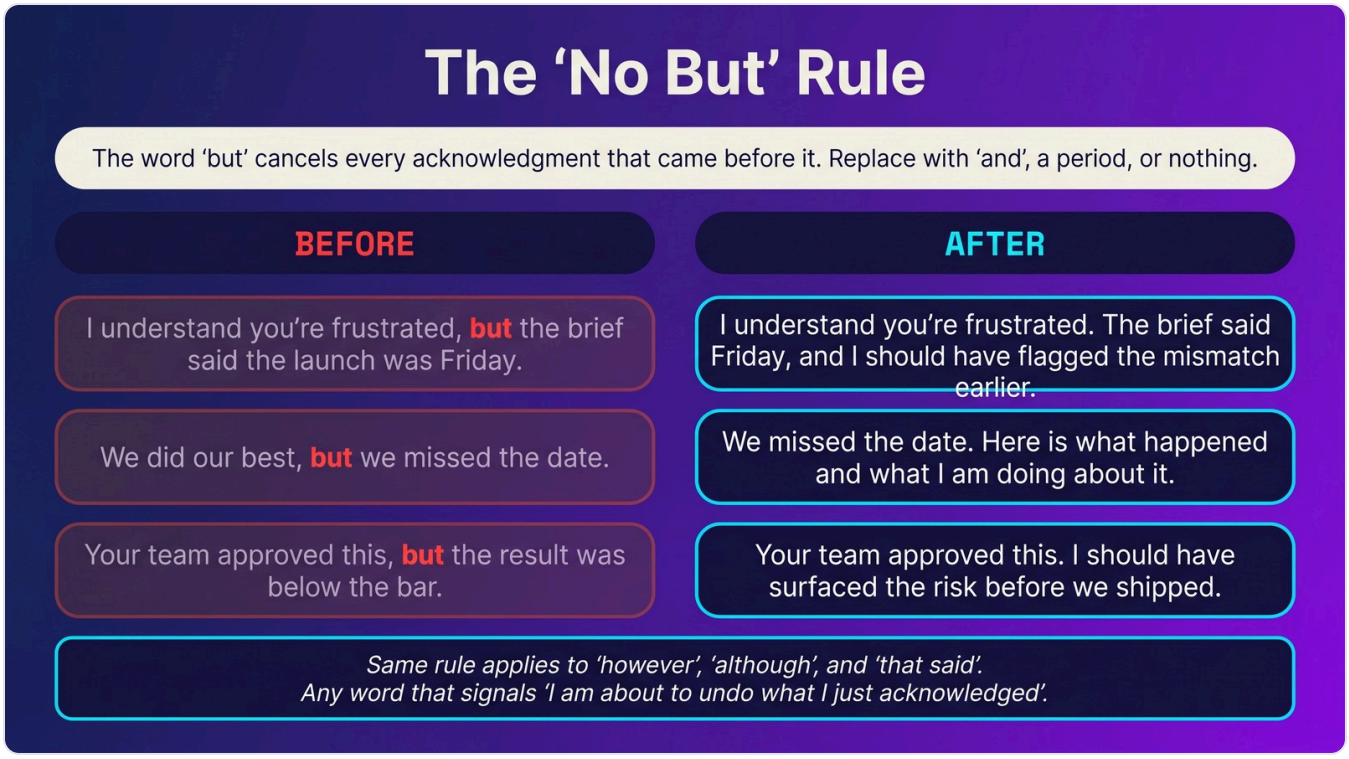
Use the openers and closers as a starter, not a script. Rewrite them in your voice with the specific facts. Tone here is agency-owner-to-client, not corporate PR.

## The "no but" rule

Before any stage, the single most useful rule in the document:

**Do not use the word "but" in any recovery message.**

It cancels everything that came before it. "I hear you, but we did send the report on time" is the client hearing "you are wrong". Replace with "and", a period, or nothing.




- "I understand you're frustrated, but the brief said..." → "I understand you're frustrated. The brief said... and I should have flagged that mismatch earlier."
- "We did our best, but we missed the date." → "We missed the date. Here is what happened and what I am doing about it."
- "Your team approved this, but..." → "Your team approved this. I should have surfaced the risk before we shipped."

The rule applies to "however", "although", and "that said" too. Any word that signals "I am about to undo what I just acknowledged".

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## Stage 1, Empathetic Acknowledgment

**What it does:** signals you have read the message, heard the emotion, registered the substance. Without it, every later stage reads as cold. Always the opening move, every tier.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "I read your note this morning and sat with it before replying. You are right to be frustrated."
- "Got your message. Before I say anything else, you are not wrong to feel this way."

- "I want to start by saying I hear you. The frustration is fair, and I'm not going to pretend it isn't."
- "Thanks for being direct with me. I would rather have this conversation than the one where you say nothing and quietly leave."
- "I've read your message a couple of times to make sure I'm responding to what you actually said, not what's easier for me to respond to."

**5 closers:**

- "Before I get into specifics, I wanted you to know that the frustration is heard and it is valid."
- "I'd rather take 30 more minutes to write you a real response than fire back something half-thought."
- "I'm not going to talk you out of how you're feeling. I'm going to address it."
- "If anything in my reply misses what you actually meant, tell me. I would rather be corrected than assume."
- "I'm taking this seriously. The next message from me has the specifics."

**Common pitfall:** rushing past acknowledgment to get to the explanation. Two sentences of empathy is not enough if the client wrote three paragraphs. Match the energy of their message before you respond to its content.

**Real-world example:** a client emailed me at 11pm furious about a missed launch window. I forced myself to send an acknowledgment-only message at 7am. Three sentences, no defense, no plan. The reply two hours later was "thanks for not making excuses. Let's talk at 2pm."

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## Stage 2, Transparent Ownership

**What it does:** says clearly, in your words, that you own the part that is yours. No deflection. No "we both know the brief was unclear". Even if you owned 30%, own that 30% out loud.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "I want to own this directly. We dropped the ball on [X], and that is on me."
- "I'm not going to walk you through 'how it happened' before I say the obvious. We made a mistake."
- "There's a temptation to spread the blame on this one, and I'm not going to do it. The miss is mine."

- "I told my team this morning that we cannot send a recovery email without first naming what we did wrong. So here it is."
- "Let me say what nobody wants to say first. We screwed up the [X], and you have every right to be unhappy about it."

**5 closers:**

- "Owning this is the start, not the resolution. The plan to fix it follows in this email."
- "I'd rather take the hit for the truth now than try to manage the optics later."
- "I'm going to tell you what we are doing about it next, and I want you to hold us to it."
- "You hired us to be the operators. We were not the operators we needed to be on this one."
- "If at any point in the rest of this email you feel I'm walking back from this, tell me and I'll restate it."

**Common pitfall:** the soft-own. "We both share responsibility for this" is not ownership, it is half-blame disguised as ownership. If you owned 30%, name the specific 30%. If you owned 100%, say it cleanly.

**Real-world example:** a client flagged reporting accuracy. The honest answer was that one of my team had been pulling data from the wrong source for three weeks. The temptation was to frame it as a "tooling issue". I sent a one-line ownership message and the client thanked me for not hiding behind the tool.

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## Stage 3, Balanced Error Presentation

**What it does:** describes what happened in proportion. Not bigger (you sound panicked), not smaller (dismissive). Match the size to what the client actually experienced. Sets the frame the rest of the conversation lives in.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "Here is what happened, in proportion. It is real, and it is also not the end of our partnership unless we make it that."
- "I want to describe this the way I would describe it to my team in a debrief. No drama, no minimizing."
- "Two things are true. The mistake matters. And it is fixable. I'm going to walk through both."
- "Let me give you the honest version of what happened, sized to what it actually was."

- "I'm going to describe this without making it bigger or smaller than it is."

**5 closers:**

- "That is the size of what we are dealing with. I'd rather get the size right than understate it."
- "If your read is that the impact was bigger than what I just described, tell me. I'd rather adjust than assume."
- "Now that you have the proportion, the next section is what we did to land here."
- "I'm telling you this in the same words I told my team. No softening for the client read."
- "That is the full picture as I have it today. If new context emerges, I'll send you an update before you have to ask."

**Common pitfall:** over-apologizing. Turn a Tier 1 typo into a Tier 3 catastrophe in your reply and the client starts wondering what else has been hidden. Match the size of the language to the actual problem.

**Real-world example:** an intern posted a draft caption to a client's social account instead of the approved one. Nine minutes up, no engagement, deleted. The right answer is one factual paragraph and the process change. Not "we are devastated by this oversight and have launched a full internal review". The proportion was small. The response should be too.

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## Stage 4, Detailed Explanation

**What it does:** walks the chronology. What happened, why, in what order. No justifications, no "but", just the timeline. Skip on Tier 1 unless asked. Required on Tier 2 and Tier 3.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "Here is the chronology, beginning to end. I'm leaving nothing out."
- "Let me walk you through what actually happened, in order, so you have the full picture."
- "I want to give you the real explanation, not the spin version."
- "Here is what happened, hour by hour. No editing."
- "I'm going to tell you exactly where this went off the rails. The recovery plan only works if you know the chronology."

**5 closers:**

- "That is the full sequence as I have it. If anything is unclear or you want me to dig further on a step, say so."
- "I'm telling you this without justification. The chronology is the chronology."
- "If any part of that lands as 'us trying to explain it away', say so and I'll rephrase. That is not the intent."
- "Now you have the full timeline. The plan to address each point comes next."
- "If your team has a different read on any step in that timeline, get them in the loop and we will reconcile."

**Common pitfall:** sneaking in justifications. Watch for phrases like "and at that point" doing the work "but" used to do. The chronology reads flat. Facts in order, nothing else.

**Real-world example:** a campaign launch slipped two days because creative review took longer than scoped. The temptation was to write "creative review took longer than scoped (which the client requested last minute)". I cut the parenthetical. The chronology stood on its own and the client accepted it. The parenthetical would have started a fight.

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## Stage 5, Damage Assessment

**What it does:** quantifies the impact. Dollars, hours lost, audience reach, delayed milestones. Whatever the metric is for that engagement, name the size of the hit. Required on Tier 2 and Tier 3.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "Here is the impact, with numbers. I'd rather you hear them from me than discover them yourself."
- "Let me put the size of the hit on the table. The plan that follows is built around these numbers."
- "Here is what this cost you, in the metrics that matter to your business."
- "I'm going to quantify the impact even though you didn't ask. Hiding the math is what got us into this."
- "These are the real numbers. I'm sending them so you can verify against your own data."

**5 closers:**

- "That is the impact as we measure it. If your numbers say something different, send them back and we'll reconcile."

- "I'm presenting this so we share the same baseline. The recovery plan is built off these numbers."
- "If any of those numbers feel low to you, tell me. I'd rather adjust the assessment up than under-fix the problem."
- "I will keep this assessment updated as we learn more, and I'll resend it if anything material changes."
- "You have the impact in writing now. The plan to mitigate it is in the next section."

**Common pitfall:** quantifying only the parts that look small. If the hit was $4,200 in ad spend and a missed conference window, name both. Selective math reads as defense.

**Real-world example:** a missed report meant a client walked into a board meeting without the numbers we promised. Cash impact zero, relational impact real. I named both: "Cash impact: zero. Relational impact: you walked in without the numbers we promised. That second one is the one that matters." The client said that line was the reason they stayed.

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## Stage 6, Encourage Collaboration

**What it does:** invites the client into the solution rather than handing them a finished plan. People commit harder to plans they helped build. Required on Tier 2 and Tier 3, optional on Tier 1.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "Before I propose what we should do, I want to ask: what would good look like for you, on your timeline?"
- "I have a draft plan. Before I send it, what is the outcome that would make this feel resolved on your end?"
- "Two heads on this is going to beat me writing in a vacuum. What do you need to see in the recovery?"
- "I'd like your read on what 'fixed' looks like before I propose how we get there."
- "I have ideas. I want yours first."

**5 closers:**

- "Send your read back when you can. I'll come back with a synthesis that includes both."
- "Whatever the recovery looks like, it works better if we both built it."

- "I'm holding the plan until I hear from you. I'd rather wait a day than ship a plan that misses what matters to you."
- "If the answer is 'just send the plan', I respect that and I'll send it. I wanted to ask first."
- "Your input on the shape of the recovery is going to make the recovery actually stick."

**Common pitfall:** asking for collaboration as a stall. If you do not have a real plan, the client can smell it. Ask when you genuinely want to incorporate their input, not when you want to delay.

**Real-world example:** after a missed Q1 target, I asked the client what "fixed" looked like before sending a plan. They said "honestly, just one weekly call where we talk about the funnel together. I felt out of the loop." That was 80% of the recovery. My drafted technical fixes were 20%.

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## Stage 7, Actionable Steps

**What it does:** concrete plan with owners, dates, outcomes. Not principles. Not commitments. Steps. Every recovery uses this stage; depth scales with tier.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "Here is the plan. Each step has an owner, a date, and a measurable outcome."
- "I have broken the recovery into concrete steps. Tell me if any of them feel light."
- "What follows is what we are doing this week, this month, and this quarter to put this behind us."
- "I'm sending steps, not principles. Principles are easy to write and hard to verify."
- "Here is what we will ship and when. Hold us to the dates."

**5 closers:**

- "Reply with anything you want changed in the plan, or just thumbs-up if the plan is the plan."
- "I will report against this plan in the next weekly. Every step gets a status."
- "If we miss a date in this plan, you will hear about the miss from me before you notice it yourself."
- "These are the steps. The reporting that makes them visible to you starts on Monday."
- "If at any point this plan stops feeling like enough, tell me and we'll go bigger."

**Common pitfall:** vague verbs. "Improve our process" is not a step. "Add a second-reviewer to every campaign before launch, owner Maria, in place by Friday" is. If you cannot put an owner and a date on

it, it is not a step.

**Real-world example:** after a quality miss I sent a plan with seven steps, each with owner and date. The client circled three and said "do these first, the other four are nice but not urgent." That conversation only worked because the steps were specific enough to debate.

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## Stage 8, Continuous Communication

**What it does:** sets the cadence and channel for how you stay in sync until the recovery is closed. Removes guesswork on both sides. Required on Tier 2 and Tier 3.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "Here is what regular communication looks like for the next 30 days. Adjust as needed."
- "I want to set the cadence in writing so neither of us is wondering when the next update lands."
- "Recovery only works if you can see it happening. Here is the rhythm."
- "Let me propose how often you'll hear from me, on what channel, with what depth."
- "I'd rather over-communicate for the next month and dial back than under-communicate and lose the trust again."

**5 closers:**

- "If the cadence I just proposed feels heavy or light, tell me. I'll adjust to your preference."
- "You'll know when the next update is coming because I'll have told you at the end of the previous one."
- "Communication is a two-way street. If I miss a beat in this cadence, call me on it."
- "We default to written. Calls happen when written falls short, and we'll both know when that is."
- "The cadence holds until we agree to step it down. Recovery first, then we revisit."

**Common pitfall:** over-promising the cadence. Promise daily updates for a month, miss one, and you undo the trust the cadence was supposed to build. Promise what you can hold.

**Real-world example:** after a Tier 3 incident I committed to Friday written updates plus a 30-minute Monday call for four weeks. We held it. By week three the client said "we can probably drop the call". The cadence had done its job.

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## Stage 9, Positive Conclusion

**What it does:** closes on a forward-facing note. Not "we hope you'll continue with us", something that reads as confidence in the path. Always the final section before the sign-off on any message containing a plan.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "We've been working together for [X], and that history matters to me. The plan above is how we earn the next chapter of it."
- "I want to close with what I actually believe. We can come out of this stronger than we went in."
- "Here is the closing thought. The mistakes we just walked through are real. They do not define what we ship next."
- "What I'd like you to take from this email: the issue is named, the plan is on the table, and we are on it."
- "I'm not going to wrap this with a corporate flourish. I'll just say what I mean."

**5 closers:**

- "Looking forward to the Friday update. The first one lands at 3pm sharp."
- "I'll be in touch on Monday with the first plan check-in. In the meantime, my line is open."
- "Reply with anything I missed. I'd rather you flag it now than carry it into the next call."
- "Thanks for not bailing on this conversation. I know you didn't have to give me the chance to write this email."
- "We've got the plan. Now I just have to ship it. Talk soon."

**Common pitfall:** corporate sign-off. "We value our partnership and look forward to continued collaboration" reads like a press release. Write the line you would actually say at the end of a phone call.

**Real-world example:** the line I keep coming back to is "thanks for not bailing on this conversation". It acknowledges the client could have just left, recognizes they chose to engage, treats them like an adult. Used it on a dozen recoveries.

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## Stage 10, Regular Follow-Up

**What it does:** the post-recovery cadence. The thing that turns a fixed conflict into a strengthened relationship instead of a quietly dying one. First 90 days after the incident closes, on every Tier 2 and Tier 3.

**5 openers (agency voice):**

- "Quick check-in. We're 14 days out from the [incident]. Here is where the plan stands."
- "Friday update on the recovery plan. Three steps complete, two in progress, one pushed by 48 hours (with reason below)."
- "We are 30 days past the [incident]. I want to do a 15-minute call this week to ask: does this still feel resolved?"
- "It has been 60 days since the [incident]. Sending the recovery scorecard so you can see the full picture in one place."
- "90-day mark. Last formal recovery check-in. After this we go back to the regular cadence unless you want to keep it tighter."

**5 closers:**

- "Reply with any concerns. If the answer is 'all good', a thumbs-up works."
- "Next update lands [day and time]. I'll be in touch sooner if anything material shifts."
- "If anything in this update feels light, push back. I'd rather over-explain than under-explain at this point in the recovery."
- "You'll see the next status on Friday. I'll keep this rhythm until you tell me to stop."
- "Marking this one closed unless you say otherwise. The full recovery file stays open and accessible."

**Common pitfall:** dropping the cadence two weeks in because nothing is on fire. The point is that it runs whether or not there is news. The lack of news is the news.

**Real-world example:** I called a recovery "done" at day 30 because nothing had blown up. Dropped the weekly. At day 50 the client raised a concern that had been quietly building. Had to re-open the file and rebuild the cadence from scratch. The Friday email would have surfaced the concern in week 6.

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That is the full 10-stage flow. Next: how to choose between channels for each stage, because the stages stay the same but the medium changes the impact.

> The rest of the AI BrandFactory library builds on patterns like this. See the full set at aibrandfactory.com.

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# Part 3, 2026 Channel Decisions

For years I ran every recovery on whatever channel the client first messaged me on. They Slacked, I Slacked back. They emailed, I emailed back. That is reactive, not strategic. The channel is part of the message. Choose it deliberately.

## Slack vs email vs Loom vs phone vs in-person

**Slack wins when:** Tier 1, client is async-first, the topic resolves in fewer than 6 messages. Also wins for the initial 24-hour acknowledgment on any tier because it lands fastest.

**Email wins when:** Tier 2 or Tier 3, the message needs structure (chronology, plan, dates), leadership chain needs cc'ing, the recovery file needs an artifact. Default for any message containing a plan with owners and dates.

**Loom wins when:** Tier 2, the recovery requires the client to see something, and the explanation would take 12 paragraphs to write but 3 minutes to show. Loom does not win for emotional acknowledgment. Loom does not win when you are unsure of your composure.

**Phone wins when:** Tier 3, client has used emotional language, the back-and-forth needs more than messaging can carry. Written follow-up always lands inside 24 hours of the call. Phone also wins for hard news you do not want to hide behind a screen.

**In-person wins when:** the relationship is high-value, the client is local, the situation is account-at-risk, and physical presence will say something the screen cannot. Rare in 2026, but for the top 5% of accounts it is sometimes the move that saves the contract.

## Async-first norms

Most modern agency relationships are async-first. Clients are running their own teams in their own time zones. Demanding a synchronous call for every recovery is friction they do not have the bandwidth for.

The default in 2026: written first, sync only when written falls short. Two exceptions: when emotion is high (Tier 3), and when the back-and-forth would require more than three written exchanges to resolve.

### The Loom apology

Works when: you are calm enough to record without rambling, you have a script on paper, the Loom is under 4 minutes, it is paired with a written summary, and you make eye contact with the camera not the screen.

Backfires when: you record while emotionally activated (it shows), ramble past 5 minutes, make excuses on camera (the visual record is permanent), or record without a written follow-up.

If you are not sure you are calm enough, you are not. Write the message instead.

### The "no big calls before written notice" rule

Never call a client unannounced for a Tier 2 or Tier 3 conversation. A call without warning makes them feel cornered. They brace for the worst.

Always send a short written message first: "I'd like to set up a 20-minute call to talk through [topic]. Can we find time tomorrow or Thursday?" Wait for them to confirm. Then call. The prep window lets the client think, assemble their own talking points, and turn the call into a conversation instead of an ambush.

### When only a phone call works

Written will not save the account when: the client has used the words "fire", "end", or "leave"; a real-world event already happened; their leadership got involved unexpectedly; they have gone silent for 5+ days after your message; or they explicitly asked for a call.

In every case: send a written message requesting a call within 24 hours, hold the call, follow up within 24 hours with a written summary including agreed actions. The written-call-written sandwich is the structure that has saved every Tier 3 account I have run.

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## Part 4, The Severity Routing Matrix

The table I keep open while writing the first reply. Tells me what to do, when, on what channel, with what follow-up. Stop guessing under pressure.

| Tier | What it is | Channel | Response window | Written follow-up | Check-in cadence |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Tier 1** | Minor frustration. Late report, typo, missed Slack. Relationship fine. | Slack or email | Within 4 hours | None required beyond initial reply | One follow-up at 7 days, then back to normal |
| **Tier 2** | Actively pissed. Blown deadline, deliverable miss, surprise bill. Relationship survives if you handle it. | Phone or Loom for first contact, plus written | Within 24 hours | Plan with owners + dates within 48 hours | Weekly written for 30 days |
| **Tier 3** | Account at risk. Real consequence to client business. Words like "fire", "end", "leave". | Video or in-person within 24 hours | Within 24 hours, video or in-person | Full written Recovery Plan within 5 business days | Weekly check-ins for 30 days, then biweekly to 90 |

## The three tier-specific risks

**Tier 1, the over-correction risk.** A typo does not need a Loom and a recovery plan. Treating Tier 1 like Tier 2 turns it into Tier 2 by signaling that you are panicked.

**Tier 2, the call-too-late risk.** Staying on Slack when the situation calls for a Loom or a phone call. Once the client is using language like "I am frustrated" or "this needs to change", Slack is too thin. Move to Loom or phone within 24 hours.

**Tier 3, the no-plan-in-writing risk.** Having the call, agreeing on actions, and then not writing them down. The written Recovery Plan in Part 5 is the artifact the client refers back to. Without it, recovery exists only in memory and memory drifts. Use it within 5 business days of first contact.

> This pattern is one piece of a wider toolkit. Adjacent SOPs at aibrandfactory.com.

# Part 5, The Template Library

Six templates, copy-paste-and-adjust. Realistic copy throughout. Bracketed fields are the only placeholders, kept minimal on purpose.

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## Template 1, Missed Deadline (1 day late)

**Channel:** email **Tier:** 1 **Use when:** you missed a deliverable by 24 hours or less, the client has noticed.

```
Subject: [Project name] update, and apology for the late ship

Hi [Name],

Quick note. The [deliverable] was due yesterday and we shipped it this morning instead.
That is on us.

It is in [folder / link / shared doc] now. I walked it once and the quality is where it
needs to be.

Two things to know. One, the cause was [specific cause, e.g., review took longer than
scoped, dependency came in late]. Not an excuse, just so you know. Two, the fix going
forward is [specific change, e.g., adding a buffer day, review starts 24 hours earlier].

If the late ship caused a downstream issue I should know about, tell me and I will work
the fix.

[Your first name]
```

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## Template 2, Missed Deadline (3 days late)

**Channel:** Loom + email **Tier:** 2 **Use when:** you missed a deliverable by 2 to 4 days. The client may not have flagged, but they have noticed.

```
Subject: [Project name], late ship and recovery plan

Hi [Name],

A 3-minute Loom is attached, walking through the deliverable. The email below is the
written summary.

The [deliverable] was due [day] and we are shipping [day], 3 days late. I sent the Loom so
you can see what is in it before you open it cold.

What happened:

[Day 1]: [specific event]
[Day 2]: [specific event]
[Day 3]: [specific event]
[Today]: ship

The miss is on us. I should have flagged the slip on [the day we knew] instead of waiting
until the deadline.

The recovery:

1. [Action] by [date], owner [name]
2. [Action] by [date], owner [name]
3. [Change to prevent recurrence] in place by [date]

The next deliverable is [next], due [date]. I am tracking it personally to hold the date.

For a call, I am free [two windows]. If email and Loom are enough, a thumbs-up reply
works.

[Your first name]
```

---

## Template 3, Missed Deadline (week-plus late)

**Channel:** phone first, then written **Tier:** 3 **Use when:** you missed a deadline by 7+ days. Client has flagged. Relationship is on the line.

Step 1, message to set up the call (within 4 hours of their flag):

```
Subject: Re: [their subject], let's talk

Hi [Name],

I read your message. You are right to be frustrated. I want to talk through it on a call
rather than over email.

30 minutes tomorrow or Thursday? Windows free: [3 slots]. Tell me which works and I'll
send the invite.

Before the call: I am not going to use it to defend or explain. The call is for you to
tell me what you need to see and for me to commit to it in writing afterwards.

[Your first name]
```

Step 2, written follow-up within 24 hours of the call (send by end of next business day):

```
Subject: [Project name], recovery plan from our call

Hi [Name],

Thanks for the call yesterday. As promised, what I committed to in writing.

Where we are: [one paragraph summary, in your words, calibrated to the client's framing]

What we owned on the call:
1. [Specific thing]
2. [Specific thing]
3. [Specific thing]

The 30-day recovery plan:

Week 1:
- [Action], owner [name], by [date]
- [Action], owner [name], by [date]

Week 2:
- [Action], owner [name], by [date]

Week 3:
- [Action], owner [name], by [date]

Week 4:
- [Recovery review call] on [date]
- [Final written recovery report] by [date]

How we'll communicate:
- Friday written update at 3pm, every week for 4 weeks
- Monday 30-minute call, every week for 4 weeks
- Slack open for anything urgent in between

What success looks like at day 30: [one or two specific, measurable signals you and the
client agreed to]

If anything in this plan misses what we agreed on the call, tell me before Friday and I
will rewrite it.

[Your first name]
```

## Template 4, Below-Quality Work Delivered

**Channel:** email + Loom **Tier:** 2 **Use when:** you shipped work that did not meet the bar. Client has flagged. You agree.

```
Subject: [Deliverable], we missed the bar, here's the plan

Hi [Name],

I am embarrassed by what we shipped on [deliverable]. The work was below the bar we set at
kickoff, and you were right to flag it.

A 4-minute Loom is attached. It walks through what we shipped, what was wrong, and what
the corrected version looks like. Watch first if you have 4 minutes; the email below is
the structured version.

What was wrong:
1. [Specific quality issue]
2. [Specific quality issue]
3. [Specific quality issue]

Why it shipped that way:
[2 to 4 sentences of honest explanation. No "but". No deflection. The chronology of how it
got past our QA.]

The fix on this deliverable:
- [Corrected version] in your folder by [date]
- [Quality check added to the redo]

The fix going forward:
- [Process change to prevent recurrence] in place by [date]
- [Person added to the QA loop]
- A note in your weekly report flagging the change so you can verify it holds

I am not asking you to absorb this. If you want a credit on next month, tell me and I will
line it up. I would rather you ask than feel you have to.

[Your first name]
```

## Template 5, Scope Creep Collision

**Channel:** email **Tier:** 2 **Use when:** the client has been pushing for out-of-scope work, you have been absorbing it, and the line has finally broken.

```
Subject: [Project name], let's get the scope honest

Hi [Name],

I want to put something on the table that has been quietly building. If I do not raise it
now, I will start delivering worse work, and that is not the partnership either of us
signed up for.

Over the last [X weeks/months], the work has expanded past the original scope.
Specifically:

- [Specific out-of-scope ask 1], approximately [X hours/weeks of work]
- [Specific out-of-scope ask 2], approximately [X hours/weeks of work]
- [Specific out-of-scope ask 3], approximately [X hours/weeks of work]

I have been absorbing this work without flagging it. That is on me. I should have raised
it at the second ask, not the seventh.

Here is what I would like to do.

For work already absorbed: I am not going to bill backwards. That work is done, the slate
is clean going into this conversation.

For work going forward: either expand the engagement officially, or pull back to the
original scope.

Option A, expand. New scope includes [list]. New monthly investment is [$X], starting
[date]. I will send a one-page scope addendum if this is the direction.

Option B, pull back. Work I would stop doing is [list]. We return to the original [$X]
monthly. No hard feelings either way.

I am not pushing one over the other. I want the engagement sustainable on both sides, and
the current shape of it is not. When you have had a chance to think, can we set up 20
minutes?

[Your first name]
```

## Template 6, Communication Blackout (after going silent)

**Channel:** email + offer of a call **Tier:** 2 or 3 depending on how silent **Use when:** you have gone silent for 3+ business days and the client has noticed.

```
Subject: My silence over the last [X] days, and what's next

Hi [Name],

I owe you an apology and an explanation for the silence over the last [X] days.

The silence was on me. No version of "I was busy" excuses going dark on a client. I should
have sent a one-line update on day 2 even with nothing of substance.

The honest reason: [one or two sentences, no melodrama. e.g., "we hit a capacity crunch
with three accounts pushing deadlines, and yours got deprioritized in the triage. That
triage was wrong, and the cause was that I had not built the team capacity I needed for
the current client load."]

The fix going forward:
1. You'll get a written status update from me every Friday at 3pm regardless of whether
there is news
2. If something needs your attention mid-week, you'll hear from me by Slack inside 4 hours
of me knowing about it
3. If I'm going to be unavailable for more than 24 hours, you'll know about it in advance,
and you'll have a contact on my team who can respond

Where we are on the actual work:
- [Specific status update on deliverable 1]
- [Specific status update on deliverable 2]
- [What is shipping this week]

If you'd like to talk through any of this on a call, I have these windows free: [two
slots]. If the written update is enough for now, a thumbs-up reply works and the next
Friday update lands as planned.

[Your first name]
```

## The Tier 3 Recovery Plan Template

For Tier 3, after the call is held, the artifact you send within 5 business days is the Recovery Plan. Longer than a recovery email. It functions as the contract for the next 30 to 90 days.

**Recovery Plan structure:**

```
RECOVERY PLAN
Client: [Name]
Incident: [One-line description]
Incident date: [Date]
Plan date: [Date plan written]
Plan owner: [Your name]

1. SITUATION SUMMARY (1 paragraph)
Factual, calibrated, in language the client would recognize as accurate. No defense, no
spin.

2. IMPACT ASSESSMENT
- Cash: [$X]
- Time: [X hours / X days delayed]
- Reputational: [specific, e.g., "client missed scheduled board update"]
- Other: [anything material]

3. WHAT WE OWNED
Every part on us, named explicitly. If you owned 70%, name the 70%. Do not soft-own.

4. WHAT WE LEARNED
2 to 4 bullets on systemic causes. Not symptoms.

5. THE 30-DAY PLAN
Week-by-week, with owner, date, and outcome per step.

6. THE 60-DAY PLAN
The recovery's transition into stabilization. What changes from week 4 to week 8.

7. THE 90-DAY PLAN
What "fully recovered" looks like at day 90, and the criteria for declaring it.

8. COMMUNICATION CADENCE
- Weekly written: [day, time]
- Weekly call: [day, time, duration]
- Slack response: [target]
- Escalation contact: [name and method]

9. SUCCESS CRITERIA
3 signals that, if true at day 30 / 60 / 90, mean the relationship is healthier than the
week before the incident.

10. WHAT WE ARE NOT DOING
The things you are deliberately NOT changing, so the client knows what stays stable.
```

```
Signed:
[Your name], [Your title]
[Date]

Acknowledged:
[Client name], [Client title]
[Date]
```

The Recovery Plan is an internal contract, not a marketing document. Reads clinical and specific, not warm and aspirational. The warmth happened on the call.

> This pattern is one piece of a wider toolkit. Adjacent SOPs at aibrandfactory.com.

---

# Part 6, The Recovery Tracking Scorecard

Recovery ends when the relationship has been measurably stable for a defined period after the incident, not when the apology message lands.

## The weekly check-in template

Every Friday for the recovery duration (30 days Tier 2, 90 days Tier 3), one-page written check-in. Same format every week. Predictability is the point.

```
RECOVERY WEEKLY CHECK-IN
Week [X] of [Y]
Sent: [Day], [Time]

1. WHERE WE STAND
[Two sentences on the status of the recovery overall. Honest tone.]

2. PLAN STATUS
Step 1: [name], status: [complete / in progress / blocked / pushed]
Step 2: [name], status: [...]
Step 3: [name], status: [...]
[continue for each step in the plan]

3. WHAT SHIPPED THIS WEEK
- [Deliverable or change]
- [Deliverable or change]

4. WHAT IS SHIPPING NEXT WEEK
- [Commitment]
- [Commitment]

5. WHAT I NEED FROM YOU
- [Specific request, or "nothing this week"]

6. RED FLAGS
- [Anything emerging this week the client should know, before they have to ask. If none,
write "none this week" out loud.]

Reply with anything I missed. The next check-in lands [day, time].
```

The "Red Flags" section is non-negotiable. Naming risks in writing builds trust. Hiding them destroys it the moment one surfaces.

## The 3 signals the account is saved

**Signal 1: the client raises new work or new ideas, not just complaints.** When the recovery cadence stops being only about the incident and starts including normal forward planning, the relationship is rebuilding.

**Signal 2: the client's response time returns to baseline.** During active conflict, response times stretch because the client is deliberating. When they tighten back to pre-incident, the deliberation is over.

**Signal 3: the client makes a commitment past the recovery window.** A renewal. A referral. A "let's plan Q3 together". Any of these signal they see the relationship continuing.

All three at day 30: account is saved. One or two: keep the cadence running. None after 30 days: Part 8 becomes relevant.

## When to declare recovered vs keep watching

The temptation is to declare recovery the moment things feel normal. Resist it. Premature declaration is a top reason recoveries fall apart.

Minimum windows from the original incident: Tier 2 recovery 30 days, Tier 3 recovery 90 days. The declaration is a short written message from you to the client:

```
Hi [Name],

30 days past the [incident]. Per the scorecard the situation is stable: all plan steps
complete, your team's feedback in the last two weeks has been positive, we have shifted
back to regular cadence on the work.

I am marking the recovery file closed unless you say otherwise. Check-ins move from weekly
to monthly starting next week.

Thanks for staying engaged through this. The plan working is not the same as the plan
being earned, and I know we earned it because you let us.

[Your first name]
```

If the client says "actually keep the weekly check-ins for another month", do that. The cadence stays as long as the client wants it.

## The 30 / 60 / 90 follow-up cadence post-recovery

Once recovery is declared, the cadence steps down but does not disappear.

- **Day 30:** formal declaration, return to standard weekly cadence.
- **Day 60:** 20-minute "anniversary check-in" call, framed as a quarterly relationship review. Agenda: "how are you feeling about the work, and what would you like different in the next 60 days".
- **Day 90:** two-paragraph written summary looking back and forward. A marker that recovery is closed and the partnership is ongoing.

The 60- and 90-day touches do not need to mention the incident by name. They just need to exist.

---

## Part 7, The 12 Mistakes To Never Make

### The 12 Mistakes To Never Make

Each one named. Each one paired with the corrective move.

| THE MISTAKE | THE CORRECTIVE MOVE |
|---|---|
| 01 Using 'but' | Replace with "and", a period, or nothing |
| 02 Going silent | Three-sentence acknowledgment within 24 hours |
| 03 Defensive language | Delete every defensive sentence on first pass |
| 04 Blame-shifting | Own at the firm level, address cause internally |
| 05 Over-discounting before listening | Never offer credit before client is heard |
| 06 Promising what you cannot deliver | Promise specific reductions, not zero |
| 07 Fixing-by-email when a call is needed | Request call within 24 hours, written before and after |
| 08 Calling when an email is better | Tier 1 stays written, calls only for high-emotion |
| 09 Over-explaining | Trim 30% on every recovery message before sending |
| 10 Dragging in your team | One sender, one recipient, team informed not cc'd |
| 11 Throwing your team under the bus | Team identity stays internal, always |
| 12 Surprise discounts as guilt offerings | Ask before crediting: "would this feel like the right close?" |

Every one of these I have made. Each one is named, defined, and paired with the corrective move.

### Mistake 1, using "but"

**What it is:** any "but", "however", "although", or "that said" in a recovery message. The word cancels the acknowledgment that came before it.

**The corrective move:** rewrite using "and", a period, or nothing at all. "I hear you, but here's the thing" becomes "I hear you. Here's what I want to add."

## Mistake 2, going silent

**What it is:** not responding to a tense message because you do not yet have the perfect reply.

**The corrective move:** acknowledge within 24 hours with a three-sentence holding message. "I read your message. I want to give it the response it deserves. You'll hear from me by [day, time]." The acknowledgment is not the reply. It buys you time without losing the client.

## Mistake 3, defensive language

**What it is:** language that frames you as the victim. "You did not give us the brief on time." "Your team approved this." Even when true, it reads as deflection.

**The corrective move:** delete every defensive sentence on a first pass. If the original facts genuinely matter, raise them in a separate message after the recovery lands, not inside the apology.

## Mistake 4, blame-shifting

**What it is:** routing fault to a team member, a vendor, or a tool. "Our designer dropped the ball." "The platform changed their API."

**The corrective move:** the client hired you, not your team or your vendor. Own the outcome at the firm level, then address the internal cause separately. The client does not need to know which junior made the error.

## Mistake 5, over-discounting before listening

**What it is:** offering a refund or credit in your first reply, before the client has told you what they want.

**The corrective move:** never offer a discount before the client has been heard. Offered in message one, it reads as a bribe to stop complaining. If a credit is right, offer it in message three or four, after you understand the size of the harm.

## Mistake 6, promising what you cannot deliver

**What it is:** under pressure, committing to a fix or guarantee you cannot actually hold. "It will never happen again."

**The corrective move:** promise what you can hold, named in specific. "Corrected deliverable by Wednesday at 3pm." Do not promise zero. Promise an order-of-magnitude reduction tied to the specific

change that produces it.

## Mistake 7, fixing-by-email when a call is needed

**What it is:** trying to resolve a Tier 3 conflict through written messages because writing feels safer.

**The corrective move:** if the client has used emotional language, if leadership is involved, or if a real-world consequence has hit, request a call within 24 hours. Written before, written after, the substantive conversation happens on the phone.

## Mistake 8, calling-when-an-email-is-better

**What it is:** the inverse mistake. Calling unannounced for a Tier 1 issue, or for a Tier 2 issue that has not escalated.

**The corrective move:** Tier 1 stays written. It respects the client's time and creates a record. Calls are for high-emotion or back-and-forth needs, not routine acknowledgments.

## Mistake 9, over-explaining

**What it is:** writing five paragraphs when three would do. The explanation gets so detailed it reads as defense.

**The corrective move:** every recovery message gets a trim pass. Cut 30%. The version that says less, more directly, lands harder.

## Mistake 10, dragging in your team

**What it is:** cc'ing multiple team members on a recovery email to "show you are taking it seriously". The client now has to manage a thread with five people.

**The corrective move:** recovery messages come from one person on your side, addressed to one person on the client side. Your team is informed, not cc'd. Recovery is a conversation, not a press conference.

## Mistake 11, throwing your team under the bus

**What it is:** the worst version of blame-shifting. Naming a specific team member as the cause of the failure to a client.

**The corrective move:** the client does not get to know which person on your team made the mistake. Ever. That information is internal.

### Mistake 12, surprise discounts as guilt offerings

**What it is:** unilaterally applying a credit to next month's invoice without being asked.

**The corrective move:** never apply an unprompted credit. It was your idea, not theirs. Ask: "If a credit on next month's invoice would feel like the right close, tell me and I'll line it up." The client accepts, declines, or proposes something else. The conversation stays theirs.

---

## Part 8, When to Fire the Client Instead

The counterweight to the rest of the playbook. Sometimes recovery is not the move and the energy belongs somewhere else. I have stayed in three recoveries longer than I should have because the SOP I just wrote made me feel like recovery was always possible. It is not.

### The 5 signals it is time to walk

**Signal 1: pattern of disrespect.** Not a single bad message. A pattern. Repeated personal attacks. Public criticism in shared channels. Speaking to your team in language they would not use with their own. Once is a bad day. Three times is who they are.

**Signal 2: scope-creep without budget.** Asking for more, refusing to pay for more, not slowing down after you raise it. The relationship has become a one-way value transfer. They are growing. You are subsidizing it.

**Signal 3: payment friction.** Late payments, contested invoices, requests for "this month's payment to slip into next" as a quarterly pattern. Once is a cash flow story. Three times is a problem with how they value the work.

**Signal 4: requests against your values.** Misleading copy. Aggressive practices on their audience. Outcomes you do not want your name attached to. The work is not just labor, it is portfolio. Decline the work that compromises the portfolio.

**Signal 5: gut says no after a Tier 3 attempt.** You ran the recovery. The plan landed. Things look fine on paper. And every time the client's name comes up in your calendar, your stomach tightens. That is signal. The cost of staying is not always visible. Sometimes it shows up only in your sleep.

## The exit conversation framework

Fire a client with the same care as recovering one. The way you exit becomes part of your reputation. Three steps:

**Step 1, written notice of intent.** Email asking to set up a call about the engagement. Do not announce the exit by email. Frame it as a relationship conversation, not a deliverable one.

**Step 2, the exit call.** 30 minutes max:

- 5 min: thank them for the work to date, name a specific thing that worked
- 10 min: explain the decision. Do not list grievances. State the conclusion: "I have decided the engagement is no longer the right fit for us to continue beyond [date]." If asked why, one or two reasons, not seven.
- 10 min: transition. What happens between now and the end date. What gets handed over.
- 5 min: forward-facing close. Genuine, not corporate.

**Step 3, the exit email within 24 hours.** Captures the call. Names the end date, transition deliverables, handover plan, final invoice timing.

### The exit conversation script

```
Hi [Name],

Thanks for the call yesterday. As discussed, what we agreed in writing.

Effective [date], the [engagement / retainer / project] will be wound down. Between now
and then:

1. Complete [deliverables in flight]
2. Hand over [assets, documentation, access]
3. Provide a written summary of [what was done, what is open, what we recommend for
whoever picks up next]

Final invoice goes out [date] for the period through [date]. Standard payment terms apply.

If you would like a referral to another agency in this space, I am happy to introduce.
Three I would trust with this work: [Name 1], [Name 2], [Name 3]. Tell me if you want a
warm intro.

Working with you and your team has been [genuine, specific thing]. I appreciate the run we
had together and wish the next chapter goes well.

[Your first name]
```

### The reference move on the way out

Always offer the referral. Three names you would trust to do the work for them. Even if the relationship ended hard.

The referral signals that you are exiting because of fit, not grievance. It tells the client you are still in their corner, just not as the operator. And it makes you the agency owner who gets referred by people you no longer actively work with. That move does more for your reputation in the next five years than the retainer would have in the next six months.

---

## What to read next

Adjacent playbooks in the AI BrandFactory library:

- **The 'Just Enough' Trap (P32)** for the operator mistakes that cause the conflicts this SOP recovers from.
- **200 Headlines, 14 Formulas, 7 Platforms (P33)** for the writing craft underneath every recovery message you send.
- **The Customer Acquisition Bible (P31)** for backfilling revenue after you fire a client.
- **The Low-Ticket Funnel Playbook (P29)** for the paid-pilot model that prevents the misfit-client pattern up front.

The full library: aibrandfactory.com. New playbooks ship monthly.

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This playbook is part of AI BrandFactory's open toolkit. Production-grade systems, frameworks, and templates for founders, agency operators, marketers, and developers shipping AI-powered businesses in 2026.

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50+ playbooks across content, copy, ads, SaaS, agency operations, AI systems, and more. All free, all production-grade, all packaged for solo operators.

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We ship lead magnets that beginners can use and pros can adapt. Every playbook in the library follows the same standards: no AI fluff, no consultancy speak, real source attribution, working code or templates where applicable, and beginner-friendly explanations layered with operator-grade depth.

## How to use this

- Read it through once
- Pick the 1 to 2 things that apply to your project right now
- Ship them this week
- Come back for the next layer when you are ready

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## Stay in touch

**aibrandfactory.com** for new playbooks every week.

**github.com/AI-BrandFactory** for the open-source repos.

Questions, feedback, or you have shipped something cool with this?
**piyush@winmassiveimpact.com**.

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*Built with care by the AI BrandFactory team.*